



“An overview of Shatchakra and its significance in Ayurvedic text books”

Dr.Varun maithani¹, Dr Renu Dhiman²,Dr.Hariom³

1. MD Scholar, Dept Rachana Sharir, Institute For Ayurved Studies and Research, Kurukshetra, Haryana

2. MD Scholar, Dept Rachana Sharir, Institute For Ayurved Studies and Research, Kurukshetra, Haryana

3. MD Scholar, Dept Rachana Sharir, Institute For Ayurved Studies and Research, Kurukshetra, Haryana

Abstract-

The seven energy wheels, known as chakras, originate at the top of your head and travel down your spine. They are essential for maintaining mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being and act as the body's energy centers. They are located on the spinal cord, where the convergence of energies from several brain regions results in an intensified flow of energy. The correspondence between a certain endocrine organ and each chakra facilitates the opening of an inhibited energy center. The existence of chakras has been extensively documented in the literature, but little is known about how they form in the developing human body during embryogenesis. The Yoga Shashtra provides the most explanation about Shadchakras. The physical body is said to be revitalized by the chakras, which are also linked to interactions on a mental, emotional, and physical level. Life force, or prana, also known as shakti, is believed to flow through the chakras along routes known as nadis. Chakras rotate and attract this global life force energy to maintain the body's physical, mental, and spiritual equilibrium. The author of this article wants to provide information about Shadchakras found in textbooks on Ayurveda. Pertaining to the significance of chakras in our bodies from an anatomy perspective.

Keywords- Ayurveda, Chakras, Shatchakra, Nadi, Samhitas.

Introduction-

Although the concept of chakras is not new, there is a strong connection between these centers and our physical selves when one compares their functioning to that of our bodies. The exact meaning of the Sanskrit word chakra is "wheel" or "circle," but in a yoga context, it would be more accurate to say "vortex" or "maelstrom." The energy wheels that run throughout the body are described by this expression. The locations of psychic energy known as the chakras are seen and felt as circular energy movements that happen at particular rates of vibration. The Yoga Samhitas primarily describe six chakras, the first of which

is the Mooladhara Chakra, which is regarded as the core of the body's energy¹. Since this is where waking begins, the yogic philosophy lays a great emphasis on balancing these Chakras. The six chakras function as switches to open and close different parts of the brain. Higher brain centers receive the waking that takes place in the chakras through the nadis.

The Chakras, which are the nerve plexuses of important nerves, are connected by the Nadis, a network of psychic conduits that resemble nerves but are more delicate in origin. The Sushumna (spinal cord) pathway, which extends from the caudal to the cephalic end, is composed of seven main chakras. Through its center, Sushumna serves as a conduit for cosmic and spiritual energies.² Some Acharyas link specific chakras to specific brain regions. They are dormant, though, and not moving. Yoga practices that stimulate these Chakras can help control the flow of energy through the Nadis and other subtle channels.

In Ayurveda, the Chakra holds great importance. The six primary Chakras are Ajna, Svadhisthan, Manipura, Anahat, Vishuddha, and Muladhara. Beyond the six there are two more centers of waking, Bindu and Sahastrara. Only very advanced phases of awareness may allow perception of these centers³. In Ayurveda, one can achieve Moksha through yoga. According to Yoga Shastra, the Sukshma sharira is a part of our body and the moderator of the entire body. The Chakras have been discovered in India by yogis, rishis, and sages from many faiths⁴.

Historical point of view of Chakras-

Between 1700 and 1100 BCE, the Brahma Upanishad, the Yogatattva Upanishad, and the Vedas include the first reference of chakras. These Vedic models were used to build the Tantric Shakti theory of the chakras and the Vajrayana concept of Tibetan Buddhism⁵. There are different numbers of chakras in different yoga styles. Early Buddhist literature mentioned four chakras, which were later expanded upon. Some talked about one hundred and twelve chakras, while others focused on just seven. Arthur Avalon's translation of two Indian texts, the Sat-Cakra-Nirupana and the Padaka-Pancaka, into his book The Serpent Power popularized the idea of seven major Chakras in the West.⁶

The Vedas, the oldest known text, refers to the eight chakras as "Astachakra navadvaradevanampurayodhya". Three of the eight are linked to the brain, while five are situated on the spinal cord. Each chakra is associated with an endocrine organ, which facilitates the opening of blocked energy centers⁷. The existence of chakras has been extensively documented in the literature, but little is known about how they form in the developing human body during embryogenesis. It makes sense to look into how the fetal chakra system develops and affects the child's growth because the fetus spine is one of the earliest structures to form and the spine contains the Chakra system⁸.

Sadachakras-

The most significant chakras are Mooladhara, Swadhisthana, Manipura, Anahat, Visuddha, and Agjna. There are six chakras throughout the spine, and each serves a different function. These chakras are positioned at regular intervals, one above the other. The six chakras function as switches to open and close different parts of the brain. Higher brain centers receive the waking that takes place in the chakras through the nadis. Another chakra is described in Ayurvedic literature.⁹ The ultimate culmination of the Kundalini Shakti, Sahasrara "is supreme." Higher consciousness is housed there. Sahasrara is physically connected to the pituitary gland, which is found at the top of the skull and regulates every gland and system in the body.

Mooladhara Chakra- Muladhara, the first Chakra, represents the point in human spiritual progress where consciousness transcends that of an animal and begins to resemble that of a true human being. Additionally, it represents the final stage of animal evolution. It is believed that many lower chakras, extending from Muladhara Chakra to the heels, are in charge of the evolution of instinctive and intellectual traits found in both humans and animals. The Chakras related to the emergence of the higher man, or superman, and enlightenment are located upward from Muladhara Chakra. The Muladhara Chakra governs all aspects of a man's sexual and excretory systems.¹⁰ It is located in the pelvic floor and correlates with the nerves that make up the coccygeal plexus. It is located in the male body between the excretory and urinary openings and takes the form of the perineal body, a small dormant gland. It is located inside the posterior surface of the cervix in the female body.¹¹

Swadhisthana- At the base of the spinal cord, or the point of termination, is the second Chakra, or Swadhisthana. It governs the unconscious in humans and correlates to the sacral plexus of nerves¹².

Manipura- Manipura, the third Chakra, is located precisely at the navel in the spinal column. It is matched to the solar plexus and is in charge of all bodily functions related to digestion, absorption, and temperature regulation¹³.

Anahata- Anahata, the fourth Chakra, is located at the level of the sternum's depression in the spinal column, behind the base of the heart. It regulates the heart's functioning and is analogous to the cardiac plexus of nerves.¹⁴

Visuddha- Vishuddha, the fifth Chakra, is located in the vertebral column at the level of the throat pit. This Chakra is associated with the cervical plexus of nerves and governs the thyroid complex, as well as the upper palate, the epiglottis, and certain articulatory systems.¹⁵

Agjna- Ajna, the pineal gland, which is located in the brain's midline just above the spinal column, is the sixth Chakra. This Chakra regulates a man's onset of sexual activity and his muscles. According to Tantra and Yoga, all aspects of the disciple's life are completely under the command of the Ajna Chakra, or command center.¹⁶

Table- Anatomical Location, Associated Gland and location of Chakras:^{17,18}

S.no	Chakra	Colour	Location	Derived from	Associated Endocrine gland
1.	Mooladhara	Red	Base of spine	Mesoderm	Adrenal
2.	Swadhisthana	Orange	Below the navel	Mesoderm	Adrenal
3.	Manipura	Yellow	Below the chest	Endoderm	Pancreatic
4.	Anahata	Green	Center of the chest (Thoracic vertebra)	Mesoderm	Thymus
5.	Vishuddha	Pale blue	Thyroid and para thyroid	Endoderm	Thyroid
6.	Agjna	Purple	Center of the forehead	Ectoderm	Pineal

The six chakras- Mooladhara, Swadhisthana, Manipura, Anahat, Visuddha, and Ajna- are the most important ones. Along with these six chakras two more chakras also described in Ayurveda text book.

Manas	Below the thalamus	Ectoderm	Pituitary
Sahasrara	Top of the skull	Ectoderm	Pituitary

Relation of chakras to energy-

The energy that the energy wheels known as chakras provide defines life. We are infused with the universal life force, which gives us the ability to experience life. Consequently, chakras stand for various frequencies found in the cosmos. The electromagnetic energy field interacts with the chakras, transforming it into our bodies and allowing us to survive. It is believed that the universal energy rises from the earth, enters our lower chakras at the base of our spine, and then moves up into the upper chakras. Rather than being linear, this energy flow is cyclical and flows in both directions¹⁹.

Charkras's balance-

A variety of techniques are used to balance the chakras, including breathing exercises, visualization exercises, chanting, essential oils, quieting and stimulating fragrances, working out and meditating over the chakras, color, sound, and light therapy, which uses colors and sounds to balance and heal the chakras, and more. Energy imbalances in the body can result from imbalances in any one of the Chakras. A wide range of medical and psychological conditions will follow from this. Simultaneous disruption or imbalance of one or more Chakras is possible, as is the possibility that one Chakra's balance will lead to another's imbalance.²⁰.

Concept of chakras according to Ayurveda-

The idea of chakras is not discussed or defined in Ayurveda. Yoga literature is the only source that explains these Chakras; it ignores any physical or physiological basis. Nonetheless, there are significant parallels between Ayurvedic and Chakra beliefs. When Ayurvedic disease diagnosis is followed with Chakra healing, positive outcomes have been observed. Many psychosomatic problems can be fully healed when Ayurvedic medicine, therapies, dietary adjustments, yoga, meditation, and Chakra healing techniques and methods are applied with efficacy²¹. These chakras are discussed solely in the context of yoga literature; no anatomical or physiological concepts are included. Nonetheless, there is a relationship between many aspects of Ayurvedic medicine and Chakras. When Ayurvedic sickness diagnosis is combined with Chakra healing, positive results have been seen. Several psychosomatic illnesses have been completely cured when Ayurvedic medication, therapies, dietary changes, yoga, meditation, and chakra healing techniques and procedures are correctly combined²².

Shat-Chakra Applications in our Life - Relationship between Endocrine Gland and Shat-Chakra Additionally, it's thought that the hormone glands and chakras, which are dormant centers of supernormal energy, are related. The body's mental and emotional processes are connected to their stimulation in addition to physical ones. Kundalini Jagrana's Sadhanas involve a methodical stimulation and penetration of the Shat Chakras. Examining the enduring connection between the endocrine glands and the Shat Chakras could aid us in comprehending, to put it technically, the effects of associated bodily processes²³.

Advantages of chakras- Numerous physical and mental illnesses can be treated with the help of chakra healing and balance. It is essential to properly integrate dietary and lifestyle modifications with disease-modifying drugs. Therefore, chakra healing can be helpful as a stand-alone treatment as well as a combination therapy. The balancing and repair of chakras helps the body produce energy. Chakra balancing facilitates the body and mind's collection of positive energy and the removal of bad energy. Chakra balancing helps us stay resilient, strong, focused, and well-organized. Chakra balancing helps address hormone imbalances and glandular dysfunctions, which are the underlying causes of many illnesses²⁴.

Discussion-

While some yogic books list seven Chakras, some only include five or six. The lowest chakra is located in the cervix of the female body and the perineal floor of the male body. The word chakra means literally "wheel," and it refers to an energy point or node in the subtle body. They are associated with interactions that are physical, emotional, and mental in nature and are thought to as centers of life force. They are also believed to give the physical body more vitality. The neurological and endocrine systems coordinate and regulate the activities of the numerous body parts to maintain homeostasis during rest and exercise. The six-petaled vermilion lotus known as Swadhisthana Chakra is located two fingers' width above Muladhara and is closely related to it. It is linked to the reproductive, urinary, and glandular systems as well as the sacral plexus. The tongue and sensation of taste are connected to Swadhisthana. A self-centered feeling of ego is aroused by its impact on the inner psyche. One of the most significant chakras, the Ajna chakra, is located at

the medulla oblongata at the top of the spinal column. It features two petals that are clear or silvery-grey. The Chakras primarily address higher intelligence above Vishuddha. Manas shakti becomes more prominent in the Ajna Chakra when Prana shakti's veiling potency diminishes. The command center is the Ajna chakra. It functions in tandem with the pineal gland, medulla oblongata, and reticular activating system. The third eye, or ajna chakra, is where one can see the entire subtle world. It is referred to as the entryway to emancipation.

Conclusion-

One of the best ways to access the different unconscious levels that are available to you is to understand the chakras. You can identify the kind of energy you are experiencing- pleasure, strength, love, creativity, intuition, and spirituality—by using the chakra model. As a map of the inner world, it is an easy notion to grasp but profound. One of the seven chakras animates each of these seven energy levels. The relationships between Manas, Sharira, and Atma are interconnected. As a result, the subject of Shatchakra and the Shareera Vignana are most closely related. Eliminating Trividha Dukha (Adidaivika, Adhyatmika, and Adibhoutika) and reaching Moksha, or being rid of all ailments, are the primary goals of Ayurveda and Darshana Shastra. In conclusion, knowledge of the Shat Chakra is both therapeutic and preventive, and it is essential to achieving the objective (Moksha).

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